

Recruit Holdings (6098.T): Indeed FutureWorks: Indeed's evolution and environmental shift driven by AI, Buy

We summarize our takeaways from Indeed FutureWorks 2026, held in a hybrid format in Phoenix, Arizona on September 2–3 (local time), an event primarily targeting HR professionals and recruiters. Indeed executives and industry experts took the stage to discuss product updates and a range of topics surrounding the broader HR industry, with the central theme being how AI's advance is reshaping the hiring process, the job market, and the practice of talent management.

Several new features leveraging AI and Indeed's proprietary database were also announced. These should drive a further step-up in the efficiency and automation of candidate sourcing and screening in the front end of the hiring process, where the company holds a competitive edge. We came away with a favorable impression: the event confirmed both the steady evolution of Indeed's AI-powered value-added services and the company's ability to correctly read—and act on—shifting employer and jobseeker needs and changing labor market conditions amid AI adoption. We see substantial room for monetization upside at Indeed and maintain our view that US ARPJ will continue to rise over the long term. We reiterate our Buy rating.

Key takeaways from the event are as follows:

- **New product announcements:** Three new features were unveiled. (1) **Brand Score:** Integrates with Glassdoor to visualize a company's reputation as a consolidated score (per the company website, currently available only to a subset of firms meeting certain criteria). (2) **Sourcing Assistant:** Uses Deep Sourcing to iteratively search jobseeker profiles on Indeed, automating everything from custom message delivery through follow-up. Available to US Pro/Enterprise subscribers from the day of announcement with no additional setup required. A pilot case saw recruiter workload reduced by 11 hours per week, while candidates sourced via the feature were 2.9x more likely to be hired and reached hire roughly 6 days faster. (3) **Smart Screening update:** Through a partnership with background check leader Checkr, a new capability allows jobseekers themselves to verify that they hold the credentials appropriate for a given role (limited to alpha users at the time of announcement, with a phased rollout over the coming year).
- **The importance of hiring fast:** The cost of an unfilled registered nurse position in New York is estimated to exceed \$25,000 per seat (roughly \$842 per day against an average 30-day time-to-fill). For employers, the absence of a person is

Minami Munakata

+81(3)4587-9830 |
minami.munakata@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

Haruki Kubota

+81(3)4587-4059 |
haruki.kubota@gs.com
Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd.

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itself a cost, and the impact extends to both products and customers. A great deal of manual work remains in the hiring process, prolonging time-to-fill. Indeed's matching technology addresses this: Premium Sponsored Jobs, the upper-tier paid job advertising option, delivers hires 50% faster than non-sponsored directly-posted listings.

- **The impact of AI adoption on the labor market:** The US labor force will contract by 2.1 million in 2026 alone. With the population set to enter natural decline by 2030 and the outlook for immigration inflows uncertain (the share of clicks on US job postings originating from outside the US has fallen from the 2% range in 2024 to 1.4% recently), labor shortages—rather than AI—will be the larger force shaping the future labor market. That said, the picture varies by sector. Healthcare (Indeed's largest revenue contributor) faces persistent chronic shortages, while AI's impact is already surfacing among entry-level white-collar roles: the new-graduate unemployment rate stood at 5.7% as of May 2026, a four-year high, and companies in the top 40% by AI exposure have cut youth and entry-level postings by roughly 20%. At the same time, cases are emerging where AI costs exceed the labor costs they were meant to displace, and AI agent token consumption is projected to rise 24x over the next four years. Corporate budget allocation is accordingly shifting from “tokenmaxxing”—opening access broadly and treating usage volume as a KPI—toward “token-minimizing,” which imposes caps and demands a business case.
- **Indeed's focus on reaching passive candidates and surfacing latent potential:** With hiring, job changes, and layoffs all running at low levels and people cautious about switching jobs—and with younger cohorts discovering career information through social media and AI assistants rather than keyword search—Indeed is concentrating on activating the passive candidate pool. Efforts to broaden touchpoints include sports sponsorships, expanded career-related content, and a ChatGPT integration. In addition, Career Scout, the company's AI career coach, draws out skills, preferences, and capabilities that jobseekers themselves have not articulated, thereby enriching their profiles. Jobseekers with detailed profiles are 4.5x more likely to be contacted by employers and 90% more likely to advance in the selection process.
- **The adverse effect of AI-automated applications and screening:** With generative AI driving application costs to near zero, application volume has exploded without a commensurate rise in quality, creating a vicious cycle. Jobseekers now require 400–750 applications to land a single offer, while employers process the surge using AI screening. Yet 84% of recruiting teams report increased workload, and 88% are concerned that their own AI screening may be rejecting qualified candidates. Employers also face growing concerns around identity fraud via deepfakes. Against this backdrop, mechanisms to verify that a candidate's skills and background are genuine (such as credential verification through the Checkr integration) are becoming necessary.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - Recruit Holdings

Our 12-month target price of ¥14,900 is based on SOTP, using FY3/28E as a base year. We assume target EV/EBITDA multiples of 11.9x/11.0x/6.4x for the HR

Technology/Marketing Matching Technology/Global Staffing segments. Key downside risks to our target price are as follows. (1) Macro environment: Risks include possible changes in job market momentum due to a sharp deterioration in macro conditions, mainly in the US, and a resulting weaker-than-expected earnings performance in the HR technology business. (2) Indeed monetization: Indeed has introduced numerous measures to increase monetization. Risks include progress with monetization at the platform falling short of our assumptions. (3) Capital allocation: Equity investors appear to largely expect Recruit to continue with share buybacks of a certain size. Risks include shareholder returns falling short of market expectations.

6098.T	12m Price Target: ¥14,900	Price: ¥16,330	Downside: 8.8%
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Buy		GS Forecast			
Market cap: ¥24.0tr / \$154.1bn Enterprise value: ¥23.1tr / \$148.4bn 3m ADTV: ¥56.8bn / \$354.0mn Japan Japan Games & Internet M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: No		3/26	3/27E	3/28E	3/29E
	Revenue (¥ bn)	3,697.4	4,286.0	4,803.8	5,286.8
	Op. profit (¥ bn)	630.6	989.1	1,336.7	1,655.6
	Op. profit CoE (¥ bn)	590.6	945.0	—	—
	EPS (¥)	349.8	568.4	814.9	1,098.0
	P/E (X)	22.9	28.7	20.0	14.9
	P/B (X)	7.1	12.2	9.9	7.6
	Dividend yield (%)	0.3	0.2	0.2	0.2
	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	(1.0)	(0.8)	(0.8)	(0.8)
	CROCI (%)	175.2	198.6	234.8	255.6
		6/26	9/26E	12/26E	3/27E
	EPS (¥)	145.5	137.0	137.7	148.1

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 4 Sep 2026 close.

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Contributing Authors: Minami Munakata Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd., Haruki Kubota Goldman Sachs Japan Co., Ltd..

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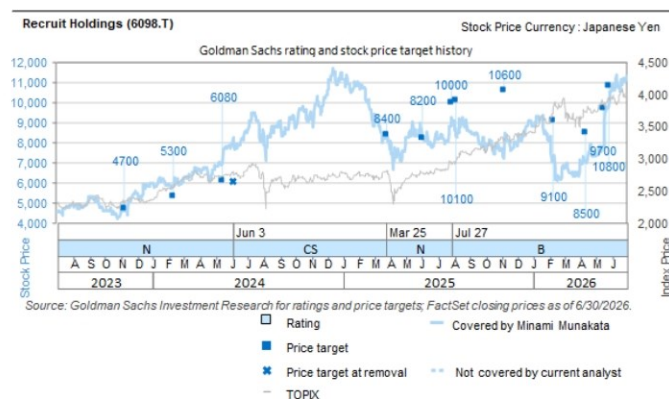
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Recruit Holdings (6098.T)

Date of report	Target price (¥)	Closing price (¥)
07-Aug-26	14,900	13,165
06-Jul-26	13,000	11,895
26-May-26	10,800	9,824
15-May-26	9,700	7,825
12-Apr-26	8,500	7,117
09-Feb-26	9,100	7,153
06-Nov-25	10,600	7,311
05-Aug-25	10,100	8,719
27-Jul-25	10,000	8,822
03-Jun-25	8,200	8,200
25-Mar-25	8,400	8,305
15-May-24	6,080	7,066
10-Feb-24	5,300	5,887
08-Nov-23	4,700	4,980

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